

Cincinnati - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Bowl-line Power Four team with a settled transfer quarterback and elite-caliber offensive-line anchors, but a very wide defensive range because 10 starters are being replaced in a new 3-4.
Preseason consensus	AP Unranked (zero votes) · SP+ No. 59 (+3.0)
Returning production	57% (No. 53) overall · Off. 57% (No. 57) · Def. 56% (No. 53)
Primer power rating	+3.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	5.8 wins · likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Worse - QB/skill losses and a near-total defensive rebuild outweigh strong OL continuity.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: A veteran OL supports QB JC French IV and a rotating backfield while WR JV Gibson leads a rebuilt receiving group. DC Nate Woody installs an aggressive 3-4 with only two returning defensive starters.

Bottom line: Cincinnati has enough OL quality and QB certainty for a bowl push, but replacing elite offensive efficiency pieces and almost the entire defense makes the projection volatile.

Beats expectations if: QB JC French IV protects the ball behind the veteran OL, the skill group replaces lost explosives, and DC Nate Woody's 3-4 quickly creates more havoc.

Disappoints if: The post-QB Brendan Sorsby passing game regresses and a defense replacing 10 starters struggles with assignments before the new scheme creates enough negative plays.

Five things to remember

- 1 **? QB question:** QB JC French IV is the Aug. 21 starter; the question is translation, not who is QB1.
- 2 **2025 baseline:** The 2025 offense ranked No. 19 in EPA/play, No. 13 success rate, No. 9 explosiveness and No. 16 pass efficiency.
- 3 **Defense:** Cincinnati replaces 10 defensive starters; OLB Antwan Peek Jr. and ILB Jonathan Thompson are the only returning 2025 starters.
- 4 **★ OL Evan Tengesdahl:** OL Evan Tengesdahl and OL Joe Cotton carry major preseason recognition and return with Taran Tyo, making offensive line the clearest proven 2026 strength.
- 5 **? Key uncertainty:** Exact offensive game-day play-calling remains unresolved between a staff with co-OCs Nic Cardwell and Pete Thomas; titles alone do not settle the caller.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	7-6 (5-4 Big 12)	● Average / bowl-level
Scoring	30.3 PPG	● Good / above average
Total offense	407.3 YPG	● Good / above average
Rush offense	176.1 YPG · 5.7 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass efficiency	8.24 YPA · 30 TD / 6 INT	● Very good
Third downs	38.7%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	25.6 PPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Total defense	399.2 YPG allowed	● Below average
Rush defense	178.8 YPG · 4.3 YPC	● Poor
Pass defense	220.5 YPG · 7.37 YPA · 20 TD allowed	● Poor

Cincinnati's 7-6 profile was offense-led: efficient passing and solid rushing gave the Bearcats enough scoring punch, while the defense consistently lost ground against both the run and pass.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+4.19 · No. 32	● Very good
Off. EPA/play	+0.137 · No. 19	● Very good
Off. success rate	49.0% · No. 13	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	15.6% · No. 9	● Elite
Havoc allowed	11.6% · No. 10	● Elite
Opp.-adjusted defense	+0.87 · No. 59	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.043 · No. 83	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	43.6% · No. 95	● Below average
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	11.6% · No. 56	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	12.0% · No. 128	● Very poor

Advanced-stat read: Cincinnati's 2025 offense was highly efficient, while the defense struggled to create havoc and prevent efficient gains. The 2026 risk is how much of that offensive value survives the personnel reset before the new defense settles.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Scott Satterfield - returning	● ↔ Scott Satterfield's return preserves the overall program structure.
Co-OC / play-caller	◆ Nic Cardwell / Pete Thomas - internal promotions to co-OCs; exact game-day offensive caller unresolved	● ↔ Internal promotion preserves continuity while changing coordinator responsibility.
DC / defensive system lead	◆ Nate Woody - new external hire from Army; aggressive 3-4 system lead	● ↑ The aggressive 3-4 reset adds upside, but replacing 10 starters keeps implementation uncertainty high.
Co-DC / ILB	Cortney Braswell - returning alongside Woody	● ↔ Cortney Braswell provides staff and linebacker continuity while Nate Woody installs the new defensive system.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB JC French IV	Georgia Southern	● ↔ QB1 gives Cincinnati role certainty, but he must replace QB Brendan Sorsby's production at a higher competition level.
◆ RB Gi'Bran Payne	Notre Dame	● ↔ Prominent member of the four-back rotation and a useful experienced addition, but no single lead-back workload is locked.
◆ WR JV Gibson	Oklahoma	● ↔ Has emerged as one of QB JC French IV's top targets and is the clearest current candidate to replace major lost receiving production.

Out	To	Loss
QB Brendan Sorsby	Texas Tech	● ↓ The 2025 starting quarterback leaves after directing one of the nation's more efficient offenses.
WR Cyrus Allen	NFL (Kansas City), Round 5, No. 176	● ↓ 2025 receiving leader-level production (46 catches, 736 yards, 13 TD) leaves as a Kansas City fifth-round pick.
WR Jeff Caldwell	NFL (Kansas City), undrafted free agent	● ↓ 32 catches, 478 yards and six TD depart with a Kansas City signing.
TE Joe Royer	NFL (Cleveland), Round 5, No. 170	● ↓ Major receiving tight end leaves as a Cleveland fifth-round pick, thinning a position without a locked replacement hierarchy.
OL Gavin Gerhardt	NFL (Minnesota), Round 7, No. 235	● ↓ Veteran center/OL with 49 career starts leaves for Minnesota; OL Evan Tengesdahl/OL Joe Cotton/OL Taran Tyo preserve quality but not full continuity.

Offense net: Worse on proven production and shared continuity. The OL anchors keep the floor respectable, but QB JC French IV and a rebuilt skill group must replace the core of an offense that ranked near the top 20 in EPA/success/explosiveness. ● ↓

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ EDGE Thomas Johnson	North Carolina Central	● ↑ Arrives with 12 sacks/18 TFL from NCCU and is the clearest imported pass-rush candidate for a defense that ranked No.128 in havoc created.
◆ CB Jacob Finley	Northern Illinois	● ↔ NIU transfer competing for a major corner role in a rebuilt secondary.
◆ S Ty Goodwill	South Alabama	● ↔ Was added as a potential secondary contributor, but a season-ending injury eliminates his 2026 on-field impact.

Out	To	Loss
LB Jake Golday	NFL (Minnesota), Round 2, No. 51	● ↓ Team-leading 105-tackle linebacker leaves as a Minnesota second-round pick.

Out	To	Loss
DL Dontay Corleone	final eligibility / post-college path	● ↓ Three-time captain/All-Big 12 defensive lineman exhausts eligibility; no confirmed professional signing is established, so he remains a non-transfer post-college loss.
DB Christian Harrison	Arkansas	● ↓ Twelve-game 2025 starter with 66 tackles transfers to Arkansas.
CB Matthew McDoom	NFL (Baltimore), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Every-game 2025 starting corner leaves with a Baltimore signing.

Defense net: Clearly worse on continuity and proven Power Four production. Woody’s scheme and transfer influx provide upside, but replacing 10 starters-with S Ty Goodwill already out-makes the defense the largest source of downside variance.

● ↓

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Veteran-OL offense with QB JC French IV, a committee backfield and a rebuilt WR hierarchy; game-day play-calling remains unresolved.	OL Evan Tengesdahl/OL Joe Cotton/OL Taran Tyo provide the strongest continuity.	Replacing QB Brendan Sorsby plus major WR/TE production.
Defense	DC Nate Woody’s aggressive blitzing 3-4 replaces the prior structure.	ILB Jonathan Thompson, OLB Antwan Peek Jr. and EDGE Thomas Johnson provide anchors.	Ten starters are replaced and S Ty Goodwill is out.
Special teams	Returning kicker/punter candidates with more continuity than the offense/defense rebuilds.	Rusnak and Fletcher return and SP+ special teams is No.46.	Return-game hierarchy is less established after Logan Wilson’s departure, and the unit does not carry an elite model edge.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B–	● ↓	Medium	QB JC French IV is the named QB1 but must replace QB Brendan Sorsby’s efficient 2025 production.
RB	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	An experienced four-back rotation operates behind the offense’s strongest unit.
WR	● C+	● ↓	Low	WR JV Gibson leads a rebuilt hierarchy after major 2025 receiving losses.
TE	● C+	● ↓	Low	TE Joe Royer’s departure leaves no established replacement hierarchy.
OL	● B+	● ↔	High	OL Evan Tengesdahl, OL Joe Cotton and OL Taran Tyo give the offense elite-caliber continuity.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↓	Low	EDGE Thomas Johnson brings pass-rush production to a largely rebuilt front.
LB	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	ILB Jonathan Thompson is one of only two returning defensive starters.
Secondary	● C	● ↓	Low	Ten defensive starters are replaced and S Ty Goodwill is out, leaving the back end highly uncertain.
Special teams	● B–	● ↔	Medium-high	K/P candidates return, but the return-game hierarchy is less settled.
Coaching	● B	● ↔	Medium-low	HC Scott Satterfield returns while DC Nate Woody installs a new 3-4.
Overall	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	Bowl-line team with OL/QB stability but a very wide range on a rebuilt defense.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Evan Tengesdahl	OL	● Nationally recognized offensive-line anchor	AP 1st · Walter Camp 2nd · Big 12 Preseason 1st team · Outland	AP first-team and Walter Camp second-team preseason recognition make him the clearest elite-caliber individual signal on the roster.
Joe Cotton	OL	● High-end conference tackle / OL anchor	Big 12 Preseason 1st team · Outland	Returns as an established front-line piece with Big 12 first-team and Outland recognition, giving French a proven edge protector.
◆ JC French IV (TR: Georgia Southern)	QB	● Transfer starter / key projection	-	QB1 as of Aug.21; Cincinnati's offensive floor depends on how efficiently he replaces Sorsby behind a strong line.
Jonathan Thompson	ILB	● Defensive anchor / high-volume returning starter	Bednarik · Butkus	One of only two returning defensive starters, with 74 tackles and a team-high 8.5 TFL in 2025 plus Bednarik/Butkus recognition.
Antwan Peek Jr.	OLB	● Returning starter / scheme-transition player	-	One of only two returning defensive starters and moving from S/STAR-family usage to OLB in Woody's 3-4, making him central to the new structure.
◆ Thomas Johnson (TR: North Carolina Central)	EDGE	● High-upside transfer pass rusher	-	Arrives after 12 sacks/18 TFL at NCCU and is the clearest personnel answer to a defense that ranked No.128 in havoc created.
◆ JV Gibson (TR: Oklahoma)	WR	● Leading receiver candidate	-	Emerging as one of QB JC French IV's top targets in camp; the offense needs him to replace the Allen/Caldwell receiving losses.
◆ Gi'Bran Payne (TR: Notre Dame)	RB	● Major committee back	-	Prominent member of an intentionally rotating four-back room that must keep the new QB out of obvious passing situations.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Manageable enough for a bowl, but Cincinnati's league slate has a difficult middle and several road toss-ups after a favorable opening three-game runway.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 46
Hardest stretch	Texas Tech → Utah → at Houston → at Iowa State
Swing games	Kansas State, at West Virginia, Utah, at Iowa State, Colorado
Advantage	The first three games are Boston College, Western Carolina and neutral-site Miami (Ohio), and the Oct.10 bye precedes the road trip to West Virginia.
Expected	5.8 wins · likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Strong OL/QB stability supports bowl pricing, but defensive uncertainty and skill turnover temper the case.
Back them when	The OL/backfield can control the game and the opponent cannot punish the new 3-4.
Fade/pass when	Facing established passing offenses or when the rebuilt skill group forces high-volume dropback football.
Key monitor	Offensive play caller, WR hierarchy behind WR JV Gibson, defensive assignments and S Ty Goodwill replacement.
Week 1 baseline	Cincinnati -7.5 · rating-only baseline; Cincinnati primer +3.0 minus Boston College SP+ -2.5 plus 2.0 default home field = 7.5 points toward Cincinnati; no matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Cincinnati –7.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Cincinnati’s veteran OL gives QB JC French IV and a rotating backfield a credible platform, but the receiving and tight-end hierarchy must replace major 2025 production. The offense therefore has a clearer floor than the defense.

DC Nate Woody’s new 3-4 replaces 10 defensive starters, making assignment soundness and early havoc production the biggest swing factors. The baseline is **5.8 wins · likely 6-6**, with a manageable bowl path but a difficult league middle.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [camp / roles](#) · [departures](#) · [team source](#) · [team source 2](#) · [team source 3](#) · [team source 4](#)

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